

POLICY BRIEF

KENYA'S PEACE AND SECURITY DIPLOMACY: GAINS AND GAPS

Assessing Sessional Paper No. 1 of 2025 Against Kenya's
Mediation and Peacekeeping Record

14 August 2026

By Youth in Governance and Global Affairs, Nala Center, and MuemAction Post

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This policy brief is informed by the proceedings of a youth dialogue on Kenya's peace and security diplomacy, convened on 14 August 2026 at the Konrad Adenauer Stiftung Kenya office in Nairobi. The dialogue was jointly organised by Youth in Governance and Global Affairs, Nala Center and MuemAction Post under the theme "Kenya's Peace and Security Diplomacy: Gains and Gaps", and examined the peace and security commitments of Sessional Paper No. 1 of 2025 on the Foreign Policy of the Republic of Kenya against Kenya's recent conduct in Sudan, South Sudan, the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo, Somalia and Haiti. Approximately 50 participants took part, comprising youth delegates, researchers and academics. Ambassador Haile Menkerios, former Head of the United Nations Office to the African Union, delivered the keynote address. Dr Nicodemus Minde and Major (Rtd) Beautah Mwanza Suba presented and then formed the panel, and the session was moderated by Aisha Ibrahim.

The consensus of the dialogue is that Kenya's difficulty in peace and security diplomacy is not a shortage of assets but a shortage of institutional machinery to convert them. Kenya holds diplomatic history, access to leaders and armed actors, a mature convening ecosystem in Nairobi, and operational experience across more than a dozen peace support missions in four decades. What it has not consistently built is the permanent capacity that turns those assets into durable outcomes. Diplomatic visibility has moved faster than institutional capability, and the gap between the two is where the country is currently losing value. Measured against a three-level test of diplomatic activity, mediation effectiveness and conflict transformation, Kenya performs strongly on activity, unevenly on effectiveness and weakly on durable transformation.

As a way forward, the Government of Kenya should establish a permanent mediation support unit with technical rather than merely political capacity; publish

transparent criteria for when and how it intervenes; create a cross-agency national repository of peace operations lessons; attach an economic diplomacy plan to every major deployment; integrate critical civilian infrastructure into the national defence architecture; and develop, resource and launch a national action plan on United Nations Security Council Resolution 2250 on Youth, Peace and Security ahead of the next electoral cycle.

BACKGROUND

Peace diplomacy is one of the core pillars of Sessional Paper No. 1 of 2025, adopted by Cabinet on 21 January 2025 and approved by the National Assembly on 24 April 2025. The policy commits Kenya to six things: to provide strategic leadership and expertise in regional peace and security; to strengthen regional capacity for mediation and negotiation; to promote post-conflict peacebuilding and reconstruction; to deepen cooperation with the



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African Union, the Intergovernmental Authority on Development, the East African Community and the International Conference on the Great Lakes Region; to promote the participation of women in peace and security; and to adopt strategic foresight and early action.

The policy describes the intended result as a robust framework. The significance of that phrase is that the ambition extends well beyond hosting talks. A robust framework implies conflict analysis, deliberate process design, institutional coordination, implementation support and evaluation. On that reading, Kenya should be assessed not only by the willingness of its leadership to intervene, but by whether interventions are aligned with regional mandates, sufficiently impartial, technically supported, and sustained after an agreement or communiqué has been signed.

Kenya's regional security environment has been shifting. The centre of gravity has moved from counter-terrorism and cross-border insecurity toward a wider portfolio that includes peacekeeping deployments, hybrid security missions and high-profile mediation initiatives. Several of those initiatives, notably in Sudan and South Sudan, have attracted criticism as well as attention. The keynote address located these crises further back still, in the formation of the African state system itself. Borders were drawn according to the administrative convenience of colonising powers, and because colonial conquest interrupted the long internal negotiation that ordinarily produces national cohesion, the continent inherited multi-ethnic states that had never undergone it. In the Horn of Africa specifically, where centralised colonial administration was comparatively limited, political and social integration between communities was arrested rather than resolved. Mediators who read today's conflicts as discrete contemporary events will

therefore design the wrong processes. It is against this backdrop that the dialogue was convened, to interrogate the gains and the gaps together rather than separately.

KEY FINDINGS

Key Finding 1: Diplomatic Activity Is Not Mediation Effectiveness

Governments commonly report the number of summits, delegations, consultations and communiqués they have generated. These are legitimate diplomatic outputs, but they are not outcomes. A three-level test separates them: diplomatic activity, measured in meetings, envoys and communiqués; mediation effectiveness, measured in changed incentives and behaviour, declining violence, workable frameworks and implemented commitments; and conflict transformation, measured in institutions, grievances and the political economies that sustain violence. Kenya's record is strongest at the first level and becomes progressively weaker as the analysis moves toward implementation and transformation.

Four tests were applied consistently across the case studies to explain that pattern precisely. Coherence asks whether an intervention fits a national strategy and complements existing regional processes. Legitimacy concerns consent, trust, ownership and perceived impartiality. Effectiveness asks whether the process changes behaviour. Institutionalisation asks whether it can survive beyond a single leader, envoy or administration. A process may be legitimate but ineffective because it lacks leverage; active but incoherent because several institutions compete in the same space; or productive of an agreement that collapses because implementation was never designed into it. Each of those three failure modes appeared in at least one case examined.

In the eastern DRC, the Nairobi Process gained diplomatic reach in the Great Lakes and rightly rejected a purely military solution, but faced institutional overlap between the East African

Community, SADC, the African Union, the ICGLR and individual states, limited leverage over belligerents, declining Congolese ownership, and political and security tracks moving at different speeds. In South Sudan, the Tumaini Initiative broadened inclusion but did not resolve the implementation deficit spanning unified security forces, civic space, constitution-making, elections and accountability. The common pattern is that Kenya's advantages are strongest at the launch of a process, and its weaknesses become visible during mandate coordination, implementation bargaining and monitoring.

Key Finding 2: Mediator Credibility Is a Finite Strategic Asset

Sudan made credibility rather than access the central question. Kenya holds legitimate security and humanitarian interests in ending the war, and few neighbouring states are completely neutral. The requirement is therefore sufficient impartiality: fair process management and the ability to maintain credible communication with all principal parties. Kenya was able to convene the Rapid Support Forces and allied actors, which is a genuine diplomatic capability. The Nairobi meetings, however, were conducted without an IGAD or African Union mandate, and the series of meetings including the conference at the Kenyatta International Convention Centre produced an outcome in the form of a parallel governing arrangement that the African Union explicitly opposed.

The decisive question is not whether Kenya could lawfully host the meeting, but whether the decision increased or reduced its ability to influence all sides. By appearing to facilitate a parallel political project, Kenya risked moving from intermediary to perceived enabler, and access to one party became a liability when it diminished trust with another. This matters because mediation is not charity. It is preventive national security. Violence in Sudan, South Sudan or the eastern DRC produces displacement, moves arms and

organised crime across borders, disrupts trade corridors and raises investment risk. Successful mediation enhances Kenya's influence in the African Union, IGAD and the wider international system, while failed or partisan initiatives impose costs in lost trust, bilateral tension and reduced ability to convene parties in future crises. A failed mediation is not a missed opportunity but an expenditure of capital.

The distinction between neutrality and impartiality was identified as an unresolved question in Kenyan practice. Neutrality means taking no side. Impartiality means applying consistent principles even-handedly. Which of these Kenya claims shapes how every intervention is read by other states and factions, and the country has not settled the matter.

Key Finding 3: Fragmented Institutional Memory Is the Binding Constraint

Across both mediation and peace support operations, speakers converged on the same diagnosis. Kenya's constraint is not capability, funding or courage in the first instance, but the absence of a systematic mechanism for capturing, documenting and sharing what its diplomats and peacekeepers have learned. Successful experience is not reliably transferred between the Ministry of Foreign and Diaspora Affairs, the National Police Service and the Kenya Defence Forces, and lived operational experience is not converted into doctrine, procurement priorities or commercial strategy.

The consequence in mediation is a condition best described as episodic institutionalisation. Kenya is not devoid of institutions: it has a policy framework, professional diplomats, security institutions, training centres and longstanding relationships with regional organisations. But operational practice remains heavily dependent on presidential initiative, prominent envoys, personal relationships, immediate crises and external funding. Institutions mobilise around a process, and capacity and learning dissipate

afterwards. Roles can become unclear between the Presidency, the foreign ministry, a special envoy and the relevant regional organisation. Special envoys are not the problem; envoys without clear mandates, technical teams, reporting lines and institutional records are.

The consequence in peace support operations is that a substantial national asset is left partly unrealised. Kenya's mission history spans UNTAG in Namibia, UNPROFOR in Croatia, operations in Liberia, Sierra Leone, Lebanon, Mali and Darfur, MONUSCO in the DRC, UNMISS in South Sudan, AMISOM and its successor AUSSOM in Somalia, the EAC Regional Force, and the Kenya-led multinational security support mission in Haiti, alongside observer deployments across seven further theatres. The lesson is not the count but the depth and diversity of that experience, and whether Kenya has systematically documented its commissions and omissions.

Key Finding 4: Peacekeeping Is Not Being Converted into National Dividend

Peacekeeping was framed throughout as foreign policy in uniform. Deployments should be evaluated not only by military success but by whether they produce diplomatic, economic, technological and societal dividends for Kenya. Against that test, the gains are real but incompletely captured. Kenya's peacekeeping record gives it credibility in United Nations and African Union forums; Kenyan officers have held force commander and other senior multinational appointments; and the International Peace Support Training Centre and the National Defence University of Kenya provide institutional depth and training diplomacy. The Kenya-led mission in Haiti is significant because it blends police and military functions and places Kenya in a leadership rather than a contributing position, which carries a correspondingly larger reputational stake.

The gaps are structural rather than incidental. Host government consent does not

automatically produce local legitimacy, and perception can defeat a sound mandate. Kenya fronts deployment costs before African Union or United Nations reimbursement, creating opportunity costs and readiness pressure. Complex missions demand intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance capability, counter-improvised explosive device capacity, protected mobility, communications, drones and medical support, all of which are expensive. Mandates, rules of engagement, accountability and inter-agency coordination can be fragmented. Returning personnel, host-community relations and family impacts require deliberate reintegration and communication that is not currently systematic.

Above all, influence is lost when diplomacy, infrastructure and commerce do not follow the troops. Deployments are not routinely paired with a post-conflict trade, infrastructure, tourism and investment engagement strategy. Regional corridors and market access are not always aligned with peace diplomacy. And public statements by political leaders can damage trust that diplomats and peacekeepers have built quietly over years. Capability itself is a system rather than an attribute: it is a derivative of finance, technology, logistics, mandate clarity and political support, and any one of these failing degrades the whole.

Key Finding 5: Peacebuilding and youth participation are under-resourced

Kenya, which previously held a seat on the United Nations Security Council, is reported to be running its third national action plan implementing Resolution 1325 on Women, Peace and Security, a record described at the dialogue as regionally leading. It has no equivalent national action plan for Resolution 2250 on Youth, Peace and Security. Drafting of a first plan is under way, and the session was used to invite students and young scholars into that work. This is the single most concrete and immediately actionable opportunity identified during the dialogue.

The gap matters because peacebuilding and peacekeeping are different work requiring different skills, time horizons and institutional homes. Peacekeeping is the visible, uniformed presence that stops active violence. Peacebuilding is the longer-term work of restoring community cohesion after conflict has stopped, of the kind represented by Rwanda's community-based court processes following the genocide. Conflating the two is one reason post-conflict recovery is under-resourced relative to deployment, and youth participation sits squarely in the under-resourced half.

A specific accountability problem was raised that policy has not adequately addressed. In post-conflict settings, sexual and gender-based violence is frequently perpetrated by figures who are simultaneously expected to help lead the community's recovery. This leaves survivors without a trusted avenue to raise the issue, because the reporting pathway and the perpetrator occupy the same social position. The mechanisms are not absent in principle; they are unusable in practice where authority and harm coincide. Peacebuilding design has to account for this rather than assume good faith on the part of community leadership.

Key Finding 6: Domestic Stability Is the Precondition for Regional Credibility

Participants attributed Kenya's outsized role as a regional mediator less to unique diplomatic talent than to underlying domestic stability. One line of argument held that, while corruption remains a recognised challenge, Kenya's political elite has historically shown awareness of the limits of ethnic mobilisation, stepping back from escalation when popular anger begins to threaten broader elite interests. Participants linked this restraint to Kenya's standing as a comparatively stable, market-oriented economy attractive to investment, and described it as both a strategic asset and a responsibility the next generation will inherit. On this view, Kenya's mediation legitimacy rests on the same domestic

restraint and institutional capacity it seeks to promote abroad.

Two pressures on that foundation were identified. The first is electoral. The Independent Electoral and Boundaries Commission is already working with the police and other security institutions to identify and pre-empt areas at risk of post-election violence, but this responsibility does not sit with institutions alone, and citizens' own political rhetoric inflames or de-escalates tension given how central ethnicity remains to Kenyan electoral politics. A concerning trend was noted in political mobilisation for hire: groups of supporters who identify well-funded candidates, publicly hype them at rallies, and expect payment or patronage in return. This is a symptom of both high-stakes politics and weak accountability, and it draws young people directly into the machinery of electoral violence.

The second is infrastructural. Kenya's defence posture is oriented primarily around external physical aggression. In more advanced systems, critical civilian infrastructure including cyber systems, the electricity grid and water systems is integrated directly into the national defence architecture. In Kenya, responsibility is siloed: an attack on the water supply is a matter for the water utility, an attack on the grid a matter for Kenya Power, and an attack on the M-Pesa mobile money platform or the Huduma citizen services platform a matter for those operators individually. A coordinated attack degrading power, water and mobile money simultaneously for even a few days could functionally cripple the country without any conventional military engagement



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taking place. Security threats are shifting toward asymmetric forms that the current

architecture is not organised to address in an integrated way.

CONCLUSION

The dialogue delivered a candid assessment of a country performing well below its own institutional potential. Kenya remains one of Africa's most important mediation and peace support actors, holding diplomatic history, access, expertise, Nairobi's convening power and a diversified peace support role that now extends to mission leadership. Participants observed that Kenya's recent diplomacy has been marked by a more activist and entrepreneurial posture that has raised the country's visibility. In their assessment, the cases of the eastern DRC, South Sudan and Sudan illustrate both the value of that approach and the risks it carries.

The principal gap is between policy ambition and institutional capability. Sessional Paper No. 1 of 2025 is a credible statement of intent, but it must be translated into permanent capacity, disciplined coordination, impartial process management and sustained implementation support. The measurement question follows. Kenya should not judge its success by meetings hosted, envoys appointed or communiqués issued. The meaningful indicators are reduced violence, legitimate settlements, implemented commitments and stronger institutions for peace.

The strategic shift required is from diplomatic activism, through professional mediation, toward sustainable peace. Kenya is somewhere in the middle of that sequence. Whether it completes it is an institutional choice rather than an inevitability.

RECOMMENDATIONS

For the Government of Kenya: mediation architecture

- **Establish a permanent mediation support unit:** The unit should hold expertise in conflict analysis, process design, gender and inclusion, communications, monitoring and implementation support. Its function is to supply the technical layer that presidential initiative currently lacks, and to retain capacity between processes rather than assembling it afresh in each crisis.
- **Publish transparent criteria for intervention:** Criteria should cover consent, comparative advantage, leverage, regional mandate, sufficient impartiality and the capacity to support implementation. Published criteria protect Kenya from the accusation that it intervenes opportunistically, and give partners a basis on which to anticipate and support Kenyan initiatives.
- **Clarify coordination between the Presidency, the foreign ministry, security institutions and envoys:** Special envoys provide stature, flexibility and access. The weakness arises when they operate without defined mandates, technical teams, reporting lines and institutional records. Clarifying these does not constrain presidential initiative; it makes it durable.
- **Respect regional subsidiarity without rivalry:** Kenya should work through and alongside IGAD, the African Union, the East African Community and the ICGLR rather than launching

processes that compete with established tracks. The Sudan experience demonstrates the cost of proceeding without a regional or continental mandate.

- **Protect mediator credibility as a strategic asset:** Engagement with armed actors must be conflict-sensitive, on the recognition that access to one party becomes a liability if it destroys trust with another. Credibility can be spent only carefully, and once spent it is not quickly recovered.
- **Treat implementation and reconstruction as part of mediation:** A mediator cannot manufacture political will but must design for its absence rather than merely calling for it, using incentives, benchmarks, monitoring, consequences and credible guarantors. Implementation is not a separate afterthought to be handled by others.
- **Secure predictable financing and institutional memory:** Each of the preceding measures fails without them. Reliance on external project funding reproduces the episodic pattern the reforms are intended to end.

For the Government of Kenya: peace support operations

- **Create a national peace operations lessons repository:** The repository should link the Kenya Defence Forces, the National Police Service, the Ministry of Foreign and Diaspora Affairs, the International Peace Support Training Centre, the National Defence University of Kenya and veterans, and post-deployment contribution should be mandatory rather than voluntary.
- **Attach an economic diplomacy plan to every major deployment:** Each deployment should carry a post-conflict trade, infrastructure, tourism and investment engagement strategy, so that commerce and diplomacy follow the troops rather than arriving years later or not at all.
- **Track host-community legitimacy as a mandate output:** Perception and local acceptance should be measured rather than assumed, on the principle that consent from a host government does not equal legitimacy with a host population.
- **Finance readiness rather than improvisation:** Reimbursement gaps, strategic lift, medical contingencies, technology and sustainment should be pre-planned and budgeted, not absorbed as emergencies once a deployment is under way.
- **Protect diplomatic coherence:** Political messaging, military action and diplomatic engagement should align around one national narrative. Public statements by political leaders can undo trust built quietly over years by diplomats and peacekeepers.
- **Invest in reintegration for returning personnel:** Deliberate reintegration and communication support for personnel and their families should be treated as part of the cost of deployment rather than as a discretionary extra.

For the Government of Kenya: domestic security foundations

- **Integrate critical civilian infrastructure into the national defence architecture:** The electricity grid, water systems, mobile money platforms and citizen services platforms should be defended as a coordinated national concern rather than left to each operator individually. The current siloed arrangement leaves a coordinated multi-sector attack unaddressed.
- **Develop, resource and launch a national action plan on Resolution 2250:** Kenya's leadership on Women, Peace and Security has no counterpart on Youth, Peace and Security. The plan

should be sequenced to inform grassroots prevention work ahead of the next electoral cycle rather than following it.

- **Expand electoral violence prevention to address paid political mobilisation:** The preparatory work already under way between the Independent Electoral and Boundaries Commission and security institutions should be sustained and widened to address mobilisation for hire explicitly, including the economic drivers that make it attractive to young people.

For regional and continental institutions

- **Sequence mandates rather than multiplying them:** Where the East African Community, the African Union, IGAD, the ICGLR and SADC are engaged in the same conflict, a single lead process should be established with the others in defined supporting roles. Overlapping mandates in the eastern DRC produced competition and ambiguity rather than redundancy.
- **Synchronise political and security tracks:** Dialogue and deployment should operate on compatible timelines. In the eastern DRC, armed escalation altered the environment faster than dialogue could consolidate authority.
- **Act earlier on warning signs:** The deterioration in South Sudan in 2025 suggested that regional diplomacy responded late to indicators visible well in advance. Detection without response is not early warning.
- **Require new initiatives to state their relationship to existing agreements:** Any new process should declare explicitly whether it supplements, integrates with or replaces an existing agreement before it convenes parties. Ambiguity on this point was a substantial source of resistance to the Tumaini Initiative.

Disclaimer

This policy brief is based on the proceedings of a youth dialogue on Kenya's peace and security diplomacy, held on 14 August 2026 in Nairobi. It summarises the analysis, views and recommendations put forward by the keynote speaker, panellists and participants. These views do not necessarily reflect the official positions of Youth in Governance and Global Affairs, Nala Center or MuemAction Post, or of any institution with which speakers or participants are affiliated. Individual contributions are not attributed to named speakers except where stated.

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